

V8 Balancing Personal and Professional Vulnerability

Pillar	Vulnerability	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	35-45 minutes	Group Size	4-12
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None (this is a low-barrier entry point)	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Team new to vulnerability work, manager uncomfortable with V1 as starting point, oversharing concerns, boundary issues in team dynamics

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

The brain does not distinguish between 'appropriate workplace vulnerability' and 'oversharing' on its own. The amygdala simply monitors whether sharing felt safe or dangerous. Without explicit guidance on what to share and what to keep private, people either overshare (triggering discomfort in others, raising cortisol across the group) or undershare (keeping the amygdala on alert because nothing real is being exchanged).

This exercise provides the cognitive scaffolding the brain needs: clear categories, explicit examples, and agreed boundaries. When the prefrontal cortex has a framework to work with, it can manage the amygdala's threat response more effectively. The result is vulnerability that builds trust without crossing into territory that creates anxiety.

IF A TEAM MEMBER ASKS "WHY ARE WE DOING THIS?"

"Vulnerability at work builds trust, but only when it's the right kind and the right amount. This exercise helps us find the line between openness that brings us closer and oversharing that creates awkwardness. We want to be real with each other without making anyone uncomfortable."

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Spectrum (10 minutes)

Draw a horizontal spectrum on the flipchart/Miro:

GUARDED	BALANCED	OVERSHARING
"Everything's fine" (when it	Shares enough to build trust.	Shares personal details that

isn't). Never admits difficulty. Creates distance.	Acknowledges challenges. Asks for help. Maintains professional focus.	create discomfort. Offloads emotional weight onto colleagues. Blurs professional boundaries.
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WHAT TO SAY

"Most of us default to one end of this spectrum. Some of us are guarded. Some of us overshare. Neither end builds trust well. The middle is where the work happens. I want each of you to think honestly about where your default sits."

Give 3 minutes for private reflection. No sharing required. This is self-awareness work.

Phase 2: The Two-Column Exercise (10 minutes)

Each person creates two columns on their paper:

- Column A: "Things I'd be comfortable sharing with this team" (examples: a work challenge I'm struggling with, a mistake I made on a project, feeling uncertain about a new process)
- Column B: "Things I'd keep private" (examples: detailed personal relationship issues, health concerns beyond what's needed for accommodations, strong political opinions)

FACILITATION NOTE

Column B is private. Nobody shares it. The exercise is about developing personal clarity on where the line sits, not about broadcasting it. Column A can be shared voluntarily.

Phase 3: Testing the Line (10 minutes)**WHAT TO SAY**

"Now let's test it. Think about something from Column A that you'd be willing to share right now. Something small. Not your deepest concern, but something genuine. Who'd like to go first?"

This is a low-stakes vulnerability practice. After each share, the manager acknowledges: "Thank you for sharing that." No advice, no solving, no comparing.

If the group stays surface-level, that is completely fine. This is a Level 1 exercise. The goal is to establish the concept of calibrated vulnerability, not to produce deep sharing.

Phase 4: Team Agreements (10 minutes)**WHAT TO SAY**

"Based on what we've discussed, what agreements should we make about how we handle personal and professional vulnerability on this team? I'll start: I commit to being honest about work challenges I'm facing, and I commit to not pushing anyone to share more than they're comfortable with."

Capture 3-4 simple agreements. These are lightweight versions of V5 norms, appropriate for teams not yet ready for the full norm-building exercise.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Someone overshares during the testing phase	Do not shut them down publicly. Acknowledge warmly: "Thank you for sharing that. That took trust." After the session, check in privately: "I appreciated your openness. For future group settings, you might consider [specific guidance on calibrating]." Frame it as coaching, not criticism.
The team treats the exercise as too simple or obvious	Acknowledge it: "This might feel straightforward in theory. The test is whether we actually do it in practice. When was the last time someone on this team admitted they were struggling with something?" This question usually reveals the gap between theory and reality.

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	People engage with the spectrum honestly ("I'm probably too guarded") The Column A shares feel genuine, even if small The team creates agreements they believe in, not generic statements
Within 1-2 weeks	A team member calibrates a share in a meeting (shares a challenge without oversharing details) Someone references the spectrum language: "I'm being too guarded about this"
CLOVER ERA data (2-4 weeks)	Vulnerability scores increase slightly (this is a foundation exercise, not a breakthrough exercise) Team comfort indicators improve

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V1: Vulnerability Circle	V8 is a lighter alternative for teams not ready for V1. After V8, V1 becomes more accessible.	Run V8 before V1 for cautious teams
V5: Vulnerability Norms	V8 agreements are a simplified version of V5 norms. V5 goes deeper.	V8 precedes V5 for new teams
C16 (merged into V9)	Empathy supports calibrated vulnerability. Understanding others' boundaries	Complementary

	requires empathic awareness.	
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